



as we go into the ISL at the right time," Singh added, expressing satisfaction with the fact that the team does not have to pay the hefty franchise fee.

Another name that shares the onus of the team's triumph is the former India international and the former club forward, Dipendu Biswas, who, as the football secretary and the senior men's team manager, took the role of an interlocutor between the club management and the investor.

"We are not a hugely invested side, but we have the commitment and the spirit to achieve it. The players have remained committed to the cause and Chernyshov's coaching acumen gave the right guidance and direction to the team to achieve the target," said Biswas, who also played a role in enlivening the dressing room by sharing his wisdom and experience.

Singh applauded Biswas' role in Mohammedan Sporting's success, saying, "He was more like a psychologist in the team as he would try to provide the right advice and motivation in trying to get the best out of the players. He also helped the coach in effectively implementing the

team's plans and strategies."

Looking at the tough road ahead after ISL qualification, Biswas said that the club will be giving its best to retain the nucleus of the team.

"We hope to retain 80 per cent of the squad and make additions only when necessary. We would like to go ahead with the players we have groomed over the years," Biswas said.

The transition to ISL will not be stark or surprising as Mohammedan Sporting has a fairly settled team that needs minor additions, felt Singh. "The transition will not be difficult as we have qualified for the ISL on merit. We had the offer of paying the franchise fee and participating in the ISL, but we decided against it.

"There are a lot of advantages of qualifying as a champion. It gives you the chance to prepare a proper team under a good coach," he said while adding that Chernyshov will continue as the head coach.

"We have understood that money cannot always give you success. Last season (2022-23) we had the highest budget in the I-League as we hired a lot of expensive players but ultimately understood money is not going to

Eyeing bigger prizes: "We are not a hugely invested side, but we have the commitment and the spirit to achieve it" — Dipak Kumar Singh, director of Bunkerhill. DEBASISH BHADURI

give you the championship. The reason for Mohammedan Sporting's success is scouting," Singh said, while adding that the management will revise the budget according to need.

"We have seen that there is not much of a difference between the Indian players playing in the two leagues. We will have to select some good foreign players for which we have the whole spectrum of the European and Latin American leagues, and get the right players in the right positions," he said.

Mohammedan Sporting will prefer to play the ISL matches in front of its fans in the city and will urge the State Government to renovate the Kishore Bharati Stadium according to the specifications laid down by the ISL.

"We would prefer to play the regular matches in KBS while having the derby matches (against Mohun Bagan and East Bengal) in the Salt Lake Stadium," Singh said.